



STRANGLER FIG In Wat Mahathat, a Buddhist monastery in Ayutthaya, Thailand, a strangler fig wraps around the head of a broken Buddha statue. This type of fig starts life as a small seed dropped on a tree branch by an animal, such as a bird.

After germinating, the seedling's roots grow down the trunk of the tree, absorbing nutrients from soil deposits on the branches. Once they reach the ground, they burrow into the soil, helping the strangler fig to develop faster and send its shoots stretching higher for sunlight. Many roots wrap around the host tree, enclosing its trunk in a network that thickens and tightens as it grows, sometimes even killing the tree. Strangler figs grow over anything that gets in their way, including walls and entire houses.